excessive use of artificial sweeteners can ruin gut and, eventually, metabolic health. "Chemical sweeteners worsen insulin resistance and are very damaging for your gut health, which is linked to our overall wellbeing," says Khosla.

'SUGAR-FREE' BIAS

Many endocrinologists and nutritionists worry about the overconsumption of sugar-free products, which contain high fat and calories, chemical sweeteners and/or natural sugar substitutes. "When did an ice cream become okay for a diabetic to eat daily because it is high protein and low sugar? The marketing of products that should be eaten sporadically has eclipsed common sense," says Pune-based dietitian Rupal Sachdeva.

Indeed, a 2016 study in the journal *Nutrients* has shown that a health claim may lead a consumer to have positive attitudes towards a food regardless of its actual health benefit. This is known as the 'halo effect'. There is also 'positivity bias', where specific nutrient information makes the consumer assume the product has other attributes (a low sugar product must also be low in fat, for example). Gorging on food marketed as 'sugar-free', therefore, is not really an option for diabetics—moderation is important, and they have to be as watchful with these as with other foods.

A small sample size study in 2023 published in *Measurement: Food* journal examined the presence of such claims and the extent of compliance with the Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) guidelines on 230 food packages marketed in India. These included baked goods, confectionery, cereals, dairy, soup, salad and protein products. It found that a large number of claims printed could not be verified due to the lack of clear FSSAI definitions.

Many businesses, however, have begun to invest in 'clean labels' instead of ambiguous claims. For example, Brooklyn Creamery, which claims to have only 4.5 per cent fat in its ice creams and 0-2 calories per gram without added sugar, is clear that it uses sweeteners, but safe ones. Similarly, products of The Cinnamon Kitchen, which sells "refined sugar free" snacks, come with simple, clean labels. "We select each ingredient that goes into our products and there are no hidden ingredients," says founder Priyasha Saluja.

However, even if a product is transparent, restraint must be exercised, say experts. "Glucose from a no-sugar oatmeal cookie may take longer to be released into blood versus a spoon of pure sugar. But something is used to make that cookie taste sweet, and all cookies contain some form of fat," says Dr Ritika Samaddar, nutritionist and head of dietics at Max Healthcare, Delhi.

The trick, then, is to not just focus on one aspect of nutrition. Even a low fat, low sugar, low calorie cookie can lead to increased sugar cravings. One must aim for an overall balance of nutrients, control portions and have correct information. Then, the occasional cookie won't hurt either. ■

While sugar-free foods must be eaten only in moderation, natural sweeteners like jaggery may increase craving for high-calorie, sweet foods



SUGAR-FREE RULES

Diabetics can eat low calorie desserts but ought to mind the following, says Ritika Samaddar, regional head, nutrition and dietetics, Max Healthcare, Delhi

- Low calorie, low GI desserts use artificial sweeteners, which can spike blood sugar, cause digestive issues and gut dysbiosis
- Many desserts marketed as 'sugar-free' are high on fats from ghee, cream etc. and increase calories. They may be unsafe for the heart
- Even low-sugar foods when taken in excess can cause the sugar to rise. Hence portion control is important
- Frequency of consumption is important. Eating desserts daily increases the intake over a period
- Nuts, seeds, dates, figs and dark chocolates are a healthy option for diabetics. Greek yoghurts with fruits are a healthy dessert option